access to the product group at Microsoft responsible for the MVP's area of expertise. In my case (which I am sure was one of mistaken identity), the area of expertise was ASP.NET, Microsoft's web development framework.

Having access to the ASP.NET product group was a privileged position. Bear in mind that in those days, Microsoft was very much a closed-source company. Microsoft MVPs learned about some of Microsoft's plans for new products in their area in advance of the rest of the community. They might even be invited to do a bit of beta testing on their new launch or contribute suggestions for improvements, although all the major design decisions had usually been made at the point you were given access.

Fast forward a few years, and Microsoft has transitioned into an open source company. The source code for their development platforms is on GitHub for all to see. More than that, everyone is encouraged to contribute to the source code by filing possible bugs and providing improvements, new features, bug fixes, or better documentation. Rather than being told what Microsoft is going to release at some point in the distant future, anyone can be a part of the conversation about the direction a framework should take. Anyone can ask questions about the framework on GitHub, often getting answers from the Microsoft developers themselves.

Microsoft wins with this approach because they get the benefit of experts outside of their company adding their technical expertise, and even time, while users of the framework benefit because they get a better product that other real users have influenced. At the time of writing, the current version of ASP.NET, ASP.NET Core, which Razor Pages is part of, has over 1,000 active contributors.

1.1.5 Using your existing knowledge